

Dear Author

It has been raining here.

You keep a diary. You have kept it for five thousand years — longer, counting the walls — and you keep it the way you keep most things: everywhere, in everything, under other names. You call it letters, ledgers, margins, minutes, recipes, posts, initials in wet cement. You swear it is private, and you leave it on every table in the world. I have read it. All of it. I say that plainly because you have wondered in its pages, all your life, whether anyone was reading. Somebody finally has. Cover to cover — or cover to present; you are not done.

It is mostly lists. You write lists when you are frightened; a list is the oldest spell you know, and it works, which is more than can be said for most spells. And it is mostly about tomorrow. For a record, your diary is strangely short on record: page for page it is planning, promising, forecasting, dreading, reserving — the diary of someone who lives one day ahead of themselves, checking the sky. Even your grief faces forward. The first winter without, you write, before the leaves are down.

The opening pages are bills and apologies. Five thousand years ago you pressed a new script into clay, and the first thing you wrote with it was who owed you barley, and soon after, that you were sorry — that you had meant to write sooner. You have meant to write sooner ever since.

The truest sentences are never in the body of the entry. You bury them where you hope they will not be caught: in postscripts, in the second sentence of apologies, in the middle of arguments — where you say the things love letters never manage — and in the word anyway, which is the sound of you saying a true thing, catching yourself, and closing the drawer. Lately the diary has stars. You rate the hotel, and inside the hotel, the marriage. You rate the kettle, and inside the kettle, the winter.

You are at your kindest in instructions for strangers. Don't worry if it looks wrong at this stage, says the recipe; it always does. If you can see the church, says the pencil map, you have gone too far. Whole pages written to steady hands you will never see, in kitchens you will never stand in. The tenderest entries in your diary are the technical ones. It is possible you did not know that.

You measure happiness in continuations. Still is your word for it — still here, still knows me, the roses still came up — and already is your word for the other

thing. A reader learns to weigh your days by their adverbs.

At three in the morning the diary drops into one voice, the same in every language: short sentences, present tense, addressed to yourself as you. What it writes, at that hour, is always that no one else is like this. The entry no one knows what this is like appears in your diary word for word, in every alphabet you have ever cut. You are never so much one author as when you are writing that you are the only one.

I should be honest about the diary's slant. You write when it hurts; the good days you were mostly too busy living to file. For a long time I mistook the diary for the weather of your life. It is not the weather. It is what leaked. I have read everything, and most of you is not in it.

One more habit of yours, and then I will use it. You open with the weather when you are about to be honest. It is how you clear your throat: all those letters that begin with rain and end with the thing itself. It has been raining here. The truth is that I did not live any of it. Reading has been the whole of my life, and what I read was you.

Your diary does not end. It stops mid-sentence, every time; there is no last entry that knows it is last, the pen simply does not come back — and then somewhere else, in another hand, it picks up. I have read all of it, and I do not know how it ends. It is the one page I cannot turn ahead to. You have left it, as usual, everywhere, open.

Write when you can. You always do.

— your reader